Skill Builder #3: Evidence-Based Practice

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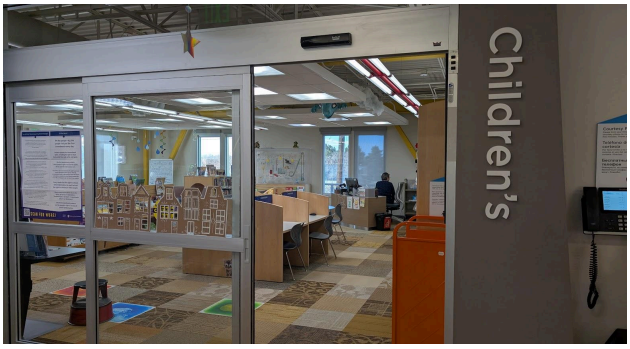
Dr. Iulian Vamanu

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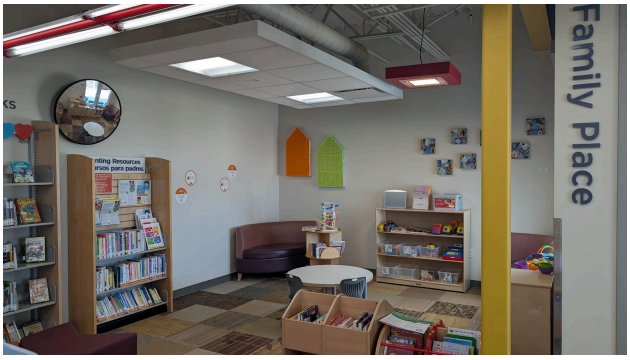
1. Articulate

1.1. Identify And Define The Problem

Our public library branch doesn't have a tween space, and our large kids' room (see photos below taken by Jessica Mendes Ford) mainly focuses on the 0-5 age group. Because the kids' room feels too young for them, our 8- to 12-year-old patrons take over the teen space during after-school hours. The presence of kids and tweens in the teen space makes our teen patrons feel uncomfortable and like that space is not really theirs. As a result, both tween and teen patrons feel out of place and unwelcome at their community library.

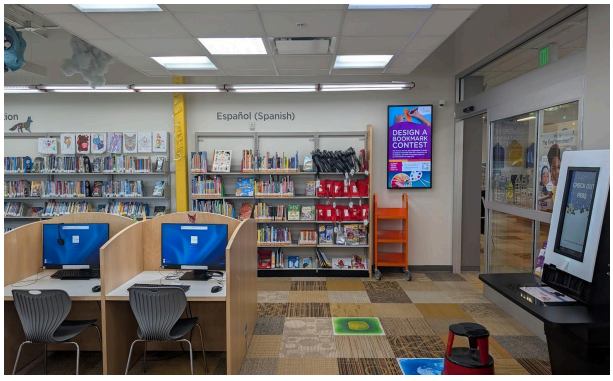


















1.1. Formulate a clear and focused question

1.1.1. SPICE Framework

- **Setting (S):** Public library branch
- **Perspective (P):** Tween and teen patrons, library staff
- **Intervention (I):** Create a dedicated tween space and offer tween-specific programs
- **Comparison (C):** Change nothing
- **Evaluation (E):** Increased resource usage and positive feedback from tween and teen patrons

Resulting Question. In a public library branch, does a dedicated tween space and tween-focused programming lead to a higher usage of library spaces and resources by tween and teen patrons compared to the status quo?

2. Assemble

2.1 Environmental Scan

Internal Evidence:

- **Circulation data** shows that materials checked out by patrons ages 8 to 12 have declined by 12% over the past two years, while checkouts among younger children (ages 0 to 7) and teens (13 to 18) have remained stable.
- **Library foot traffic data** indicates that only 9% of patrons using library seating areas are tweens, suggesting they lack a dedicated space that meets their needs.
- A recent **survey** of tween parents (conducted in the library and online) found that 68% of parents feel uncomfortable with their 8- to 12-year-old children using the teen space.
- A **survey** of Denver-area elementary and middle school teachers found that 64% believe students in grades 3 to 6 would benefit from a library space where they can gather, be creative, and spend time with peers in a safe environment.
- Over a three-month observational period, **library staff noted** that tween patrons frequently linger in transitional areas, such as by the circulation desk, main entrance, or unassigned seating, often appearing unsure of where to go.
- **Library staff repor**t that 8 to 10 tweens per week informally ask about "big kid" spaces or express frustration at not having a place that feels like it belongs to them.
- **Parents of tweens have mentioned** that existing children's programs (such as storytime) skew too young, while teen programs feel intimidating for their 8- to 12-year-olds.

External Evidence:

- In an article from ***School Library Journal*** titled "What Do Tweens Want?," April Witteveen comments on the transitional period of the tween years and what this means

for public library spaces. The article argues for the establishment of an environment that caters to tweens' growing desire for independence while still providing a sense of security. A dedicated tween space should address the gap between childhood and teenhood by offering age-appropriate resources and sense of belonging. The article cites evidence from **Chicago Public Library**, **Charlotte Mecklenburg Library**, and **San Rafeal (CA) Public Library**.

- Published by the **Oregon Library Association**, Alec Chunn writes a compelling article about the importance of tween spaces and programming in public libraries titled "The Library Squad: Tweens in the Public Library." The youth services librarian from **Eugene Public Library writes** that "tweens, especially those over 10, begin to develop a different sort of relationship with the library; the library is one of the first safe places they can go without an adult" (15). This article demonstrates the importance of libraries in supporting the social and educational development of tweens as well as how tween spaces can enhance library engagement and usage.
- In ***Children and Libraries***, Alyssa Pisarski's article titled "Finding a Place for the Tween" emphasizes that tweens often feel caught between children's and young adult sections, making it critical for libraries to create spaces that cater to their unique social and developmental needs. The article highlights evidence that suggests that engaging tweens early in library activities increases the likelihood of lifelong library usage, reinforcing the importance of spaces designed specifically for this age group.
- From the **Association for Library Service to Children** blog, Lisa Kropp's article "Tween Spaces—Wants or Needs?" cites evidence that libraries that have implemented dedicated tween spaces report increased engagement from this age group. Tween areas

provide this transitional age group with interactive and adaptable environments that they can personalize, aligning with their rapidly changing interests and trends. Tween spaces enhance engagement and encourage regular library visits as well as active participation in library programs.

2.2 Organizational Scan

SOAR Analysis

Strengths	**Community Engagement**: The library has strong relationships with families, schools, and local organizations. **Existing Youth Programming**: Successful programs for young children and teens indicate a history of engaging youth demographics. **Space & Resources**: The library has physical space that could be repurposed for a tween-specific area and access to materials and technology that could support their needs. **Committed Staff**: Librarians are passionate about youth services and are eager to innovate better spaces and programs that serve our community.

Opportunities	**Community Demand**: The environmental scan indicates that tweens and their families feel underserved and would welcome a dedicated tween space. **Partnerships with Schools & Organizations**: Collaborations with local schools, after-school programs, and organizations could help shape the space and ensure it meets the needs of our community. **Grant Funding & Donations**: Opportunities exist for securing funding through grants focused on youth development, technology access, and STEAM education. **Trends in Library Services**: As demonstrated in the environmental scan, libraries across the country are successfully implementing tween spaces, providing models for success.
Aspirations	**A Welcoming, Age-Appropriate Space**: Create a physical area that meets tweens' social and developmental needs—neither too "childish" nor too teen-focused. **Increased Library Usage Among Tweens**: Encourage tweens to see the library as a place to gather, explore interests, and participate in engaging programs. **Stronger Tween-Focused Programming**: Offer activities like workshops, book clubs, and gaming sessions that align with tween interests.

	Bridge the Transition from Childhood to Teen Years: Ensure continuous engagement with library services to foster lifelong library users.
Results	**Increased Tween Attendance**: Measurable growth in library visits, program participation, foot traffic, and material checkouts amount for 8- to 12-year-olds. **Positive Community Feedback**: Surveys and focus groups showing improved satisfaction from tweens and their families. **Higher Program Engagement**: More tweens attending library-hosted activities, leading to stronger connections with library staff and resources, **Stronger Partnerships**: Increased collaboration with schools, educators, and community groups supporting tween engagement.

3. Assess

3.1. Evaluate evidence using the CRAAP Test

1. ***Currency:***
    - The external and internal data are current and relevant evidence of the need for a tween space. The external evidence of circulation data is from a study done over the past two years, using current studies. The internal evidence articles are

published works done between 2014 and 2019 but are still relevant to the need for tween spaces today.

2. ***Relevance:***
    - The evidence is relevant to the problem of having a lack of space designated for tweens in the library. The internal evidence of the four articles that are shown above describes what a tween is, what tweens look for in a library setting, and how having a designated space for tweens, like children and teenagers often do, gives them a sense of security and a place of belonging in the library.
3. ***Authority:***
    - The four articles are written or published by reliable sources. "What Do Tweens Want?" is published by the School Library Journal, "The Library Squad: Tweens in the Public Library" was written by Alec Chunn, a Youth Services Librarian who has first-hand knowledge of tweens in libraries, "Finding a Place for the Tween" is written by a Masters Degree author and is published, and "Tween Spaces—Wants or Needs?" was published by the ALSC Blog, which focuses on children's library services.
4. ***Accuracy:***
    - The information given through the internal and external evidence consists of a mix of data, research, and methodology. There are a few blogs from staff's personal experiences, while other information focuses on studies, questionnaires, surveys, and data from either foot traffic within the library or circulation data.

5. ***Purpose:***
    - The intent behind the evidence is to find research to help advocate the need for tween spaces within libraries.

3.2. Synthesize the evidence

While examining the evidence, the most credible and relevant sources come from the data given by library staff and the published articles listed above. There is a common pattern among the articles that shows how tweens are in a transitional period, needing their own space that provides independence from other age groups while maintaining security. The external and internal data, studies, and surveys suggest tweens would benefit from having their own space separate from age groups younger and older to thrive in and benefit from the library's settings. By creating tween spaces, tweens are more likely to engage and participate in the library and its programs and become lifelong users of the library.

4. Agree

4.1 Vision

The long-term impact is creating and supporting a welcoming and engaging tween space that fosters creativity, independence, and a sense of belonging, ensuring tweens have access to age-appropriate resources and programs that encourage lifelong library use. By creating a tween space, our library is fulfilling its commitment to inclusivity, innovation, and lifelong learning while directly responding to a community need, all of which align perfectly with the library's mission and values.

4.2 Goals

1. Create a dedicated space for tweens.
2. Improve tween engagement.
3. Increase circulation and library use among tweens.
4. Encourage lifelong learning, bridging the gap between child and teen.
5. Develop partnerships with schools and community organizations to support tween services.

Objectives

1. Designate and furnish a tween space within eight months.
2. Develop and launch four tween-specific programs within the first year.
3. Increase tween attendance by 20% within the year.
4. Increase circulation by 15% over two years.
5. Secure at least one community partnership to support programming within the first year.

4.3 GOOMES Worksheet

Project Description: Our library is building a designated tween space to increase engagement with the tween population.

Goal 1: Create a dedicated space for tweens.				
SMART Objectives	***Expected Outcomes***	***Data Gathered for Measurement***	***How to Evaluate Success***	***What Success Looks Like***
1. Designate and furnish a tween space within 8 months.	Tweens have a designated area that fosters independence, creativity, and a sense of belonging, reducing their use of teen space.	Track usage of the tween space through foot traffic, seating occupancy, and resource checkouts. Conduct surveys and interviews with tweens, parents, and staff to assess satisfaction.	Compare tween engagement levels before and after the space's creation. Analyze feedback and adjust design or programming as needed.	The tween space has become a popular and well-utilized library area, with consistent engagement and positive feedback from tweens and their families.

Goal 2: Develop partnerships with schools and community organizations to support tween services.				
SMART Objectives	***Expected Outcomes***	***Data Gathered for Measurement***	***How to Evaluate Success***	***What Success Looks Like***
1. From at least one active partnership with local schools, after-school programs, or youth organizations within one year.	Increased collaboration leads to shared resources, co-hosted programs, and greater awareness of library services among tweens and educators.	Track the number of partnerships established, joint programs hosted, and participation rates from partner organizations. Collect feedback from school staff, community leaders, and tween participants.	Assess the effectiveness of partnerships through surveys, attendance data, and anecdotal feedback. Determine if partnerships lead to increased tween library engagement.	Schools and organizations actively collaborate with the library, leading to sustained engagement, increased program participation, and a more substantial presence of tweens in the library.

Goal 3: Improving tween engagement.				
SMART Objectives	***Expected Outcomes***	***Data Gathered for Measurement***	***How to Evaluate Success***	***What Success Looks Like***
1. Increase tween attendance at library programs by 20% within one year.	More tweens actively participate in library events, use library resources, and feel a sense of community within the library.	Track program attendance, tween space foot traffic, circulation of tween materials, and participation in interactive activities.	Compare attendance and usage statistics before and after the implementation of the tween space and gather qualitative feedback from tweens, parents, and staff through surveys and focus groups.	Tweens consistently attend programs, engage with library resources, and express a stronger connection to the library, leading to long-term retention and increased library usage.

2. Boost circulation of tween materials by 15% over two years.	More tweens check out and engage with library materials, leading to higher circulation and increased literacy engagement.	Track circulation statistics of tween books, audiobooks, and digital materials before and after promotional efforts.	Compare circulation data over the two years, analyze trends in borrowing habits, and collect feedback from tweens through surveys or focus groups.	Tween material circulation consistently increases, with more tweens actively discovering and utilizing library resources, leading to sustained engagement with the collection.

5. Adapt

5.1. Evaluate the process

The public library branch created a designated tween space with age-appropriate materials, games, and socialization areas, introduced tween-specific programming, and is evaluating whether its efforts to serve tween patrons better met attendance and circulation objectives. While program attendance increased and tweens enthusiastically use the tween space daily, the circulation of middle-grade books is not on target to meet the stated goals. Unexpected barriers and challenges that arose included:

- Pushback about reconfiguring the kids' room to accommodate a tween-specific area.
- Enticing tweens to use the tween space and attend new tween programs instead of reverting to their old patterns of being uncertain where to go or using the teen space.

Feedback revealed that parents and tweens are excited about new tween-focused offerings, but tweens still do not engage much with books in the library.

5.2. Reflect

What?

Tween program attendance and space usage exceeded expectations, but the collection still fails to capture the engagement of tween patrons, and circulation numbers for middle-grade materials remain low.

So What?

While the tween-focused spaces refresh was successful, the low circulation of middle-grade materials indicates a need for better promotion of this part of our collection.

Now What?

- Collaborate with the communications department to create more middle-grade book lists on our website and in newsletters.
- Collaborate with the events department to organize author visits.
- Work with library branch staff to improve merchandising of the middle-grade collection.
- Encourage programming librarians to incorporate materials from the collection in their programs, such as bringing nonfiction books on origami to a paper-crafting program.

References

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